

**VIETNAMESE POST-VERBAL *ĐƯỢC*:
ASPECTUALITY, MODALITY, PREDICATION,
AND SPEAKER COMMITMENT**

Trần Phan¹ and Barbara Meisterernst²

¹*National Tsing Hua University*

²*University of Stuttgart*

ABSTRACT

This study first argues that Vietnamese *được* (lit. ‘gain, acquire, come to have’) indicates only dynamic readings in the capacity of a post-verbal modal auxiliary. If a post-verbal *được* is not interpreted dynamically, it does not serve as a modal auxiliary, but is either an aspectual marker of telicity, an evaluative predicate, or a pragmatic marker. We then address the syntactic and interpretive properties of post-verbal *được*, adopting the view that *được* heads a functional projection below VP when encoding either Aktionsart or dynamic modal meaning. In sentences with a denial illocutionary force, sentence-final *được* is analyzed as a commitment marker (Krifka 2015, 2023; Wiltschko & Heim 2016) communicating the speaker’s public endorsement of the denial of a previous utterance.

Keywords: *post-verbal được, aspectuality, modality, predication, speaker commitment, syntax-pragmatics interface*

1. INTRODUCTION

Vietnamese *được* has many faces. As a lexical verb it roughly means ‘gain, acquire, come to have’, having cognates in many Sinitic varieties and mainland Southeast Asia languages (see Simpson 2001; Enfield 2003). As a modal auxiliary, *được* ‘can’ either precedes or follows the main verb (V), albeit with an interpretative difference: post-verbal *được* as in (1a) yields a dynamic reading, while pre-verbal *được* in (1b) is construed deontically.¹ Pioneering studies on *được* (e.g. Duffield 1999; Simpson 2001) already notice that this post-verbal position is unexpected considering how other modal elements in the language are systematically pre-verbal. This linear ordering is illustrated with deontic *phải* ‘must’ and *nên* ‘should’ in (2).

- (1) a. *Tí vật được con trâu đó.*
Tí wrestle DUOC² CL buffalo that
‘Tí is able to wrestle that buffalo.’ [dynamic]
b. *Tí được vật con trâu đó.*
Tí DUOC wrestle CL buffalo that
‘Tí is permitted to wrestle that buffalo.’ [deontic]

¹ A quick note on terminologies. We adopt Portner’s (2009) categorization of sentential modality into three classes: epistemic, priority, and dynamic. Epistemics are modals generally concerning the speaker’s evaluation and judgment in light of her knowledge. Deontics belong to the class of priority modals, pertaining to what is necessary as well as possible given a set of moral principles or a body of law (von Stechow 2006). (Volitional) dynamic modals concern how (internal/external) circumstances impact the actions of a volitional individual. The two types of dynamic readings relevant to this study are ability (related to the stable properties of the subject) and opportunity (concerning “accidental or stable properties of the utterance situation” (Hackl 1998:26)).

² The abbreviations are glossed as follows: ASP = aspect; ANT = anterior; CL = classifier; COP = copula; FUT = future; HON = honorific; MP = modal particle; NEG = negation; PL = plural; PRT = particle; SG = singular; SFP = sentence-final particle; TOP = topic marker. Certain original glosses have been modified to align with the stylistic conventions used in this paper.

- (2) *Tí phải/nên vật con trâu đó.*
 Tí must should wrestle CL buffalo that
 ‘Tí must/should wrestle that buffalo.’

Other dynamic modals in the language, whether still in use or not, are also restricted to a pre-verbal position. Phan (2024a) claims that a group of now-obsolete modal verbs of dynamic possibility, including *hay*, *khá/khả*, and *kham*, are only attested pre-verbally, see (3) for illustration. Note that post-verbal *được* in (3) is assumed to have an aspectual reading, a point to which we will return briefly. Phan (2024a) further postulates that even *được* once functioned pre-verbally as an opportunity modal, as illustrated in (4). *Có thể* ‘can’, generally regarded as the canonical dynamic modal in Present-Day Vietnamese, also precedes the verb, see (5).

- (3) *Ai hay cóc được, mới óc là đã.*
 who can understand with.success only say COP complete
 ‘Only those who can successfully understand it are said to be complete.’ (*Cư trần*, 13th c.) (Phan 2024a:169)

- (4) *tôi [...] thấy thầy Thiêm đọc một tờ lý đoán*
 1SG see catechist Thiêm read one CL judgment
phạt Đức Cụ trong ấy nói nhiều lời tôi
 punish HON elderly in there say many word 1SG
chẳng được thuộc hết
 NEG DUOC memorize exhaust
 ‘I [...] saw Mr. Thiêm the catechist read a judgment specifying the punishment of The Honorable in which it mentioned many things I could not memorize in their entirety’ (*Thư* 18, 1759) (Phan 2024a:184)

- (5) *Tí có thể vật con trâu đó.*
 Tí can wrestle CL buffalo that
 ‘Tí can wrestle that buffalo.’

To account for its curious position, Phan (2024a) suggests that post-verbal *được* is diachronically derived from *được* as a resultative marker

(meaning roughly ‘successfully, with success’), marking inner aspect. With this reading, *được* heads a functional projection (mnemonically dubbed RP) selected by V. See (3) above for an example of this use, and Section 3 for more discussions on its aspectual nature. To derive its modal reading, Phan (2024a) proposes that *được* first raises to a secondary Modal Phrase (ModP) below VP before being reanalyzed as the head of this projection at a later stage of its diachronic development. This ModP is licensed by a canonical modal projection above VP (realized as *có thể*) via *Agree*, in compliance with the consensus that a hierarchical arrangement is established universally where functional structures c-command a lexical projection (cf. Cinque 1999).

Although the modal function remains the most intriguing aspect of a post-verbal *được*, we find it worthwhile to show that this element can serve other functions corresponding to diverse structural positions and featural make-ups. With this intention in mind, the current work is structured as follows. Section 2 proposes that *được* as a modal verb always has a dynamic reading post-verbally. Section 3 focuses on scrutinizing the syntax and interpretive properties of post-verbal *được*, both as an aspect marker of telicity and as a secondary modal auxiliary. An explanation is then provided for the compulsory incorporation of a result component X to modal *được*, resulting in the formation of a V-X-*được* sequence to yield a potential reading. The section additionally suggests that *được* also exhibits a predicative use in the presence of a sentential subject. Section 4 highlights the hitherto overlooked use of *được* as a sentence-final particle exclusively found in denial contexts with clause-initial *wh*-adverbs. We claim that this instantiation of *được* has no modal interpretation and is better analyzed as a marker of public commitment (Krifka 2015, 2023), typically accentuating the speaker’s commitment to a refute to a previous utterance. Section 5 as a conclusion provides a brief remark on the hitherto undiscussed V-*được*-X sequence.

2. POST-VERBAL MODAL *ĐƯỢC* IS EXCLUSIVELY DYNAMIC

Duffield (1999, 2001) and Enfield (2003) claim that *được* expresses both dynamic and epistemic possibility post-verbally. Duffield (1999)

further remarks that *được* has a stronger preference for abilitative reading, and its epistemic reading is coerced by *có thể*. Our position is that, as a modal verb, post-verbal *được* only allows dynamic construals. In other words, the epistemic reading (6ii), quoted from Sybesma 2008, is in fact not plausible (see also Phan 2013 for a similar judgment).

- (6) *Anh ấy kiếm việc được.*
 3SG look.for work DUOC
 i. ‘He can find/look for a job.’ [ability]
 ii. ‘It is possible that he will find/look for a job.’ [epistemic]
 (Sybesma 2008:253)

To express epistemic possibility, Vietnamese typically resorts to the pre-verbal *có thể*. In the presence of *có thể*, (7) can be interpreted either abilitatively or epistemically. Assuming that modal elements have distinct interpretations according to their syntactic height (cf. Tsai 2015a), with epistemic modal (ad)verbs merged in Rizzi’s (1997) Split-CP and dynamic modals projecting immediately above VP (Phan 2023, 2024a, b), we predict that the use of certain TP-level elements like tense marker *sẽ* ‘will’ or temporal adverb *ngày mai* ‘tomorrow’ as delimiters can tease apart these readings (see also Duffield 1999). This prediction is borne out, since *có thể* is strictly epistemic when preceding *sẽ* and *ngày mai* (8a), but is exclusively dynamic if the order is reversed (8b).

- (7) *Anh ấy có thể kiếm việc.*
 3SG can look.for job
 i. ‘He can look for a job.’ [dynamic]
 ii. ‘It is possible that he will look for a job.’ [epistemic]

- (8) a. *Anh ấy có thể ngày mai sẽ kiếm việc.*
 3SG can tomorrow FUT look.for job
 ‘It is possible that he will look for a job tomorrow.’ [epistemic]
 b. *Anh ấy ngày mai sẽ có thể kiếm việc.*
 3SG tomorrow FUT can look.for job
 ‘Tomorrow he will be able to look for a job.’ [dynamic]

Now that our intuition is sharpened, let us go back to *được*. If post-verbal modal *được* is exclusively dynamic as previously claimed, then we can make two further predictions. First, the co-occurrence of *được* with the higher *có thể* must yield both a dynamic reading and an epistemic reading (with the latter scoping over the former); the dynamic reading comes from *được*, and the epistemic reading is contributed by *có thể*. On the contrary, the presence of *được* alongside the lower *có thể* must bring about a single dynamic reading. These predictions are indeed borne out, see (9a) and (9b) respectively. Notice also how the temporal adverb and tense marker take scope over *được* in both cases. This is anticipated if post-verbal *được* indeed merges low in the structural spine and is c-commanded by Tense, which is impossible for epistemic modals considering their base position within the CP domain.

- (9) a. Anh ấy *có thể* *ngày mai* *sẽ* *kiếm* *việc* *được*.
 3SG can tomorrow FUT look.for job DUOC
 ‘It is possible that he will be able to look for a job tomorrow.’
 [epistemic > dynamic]
- b. Anh ấy *ngày mai* *sẽ* *có thể* *kiếm* *việc* *được*.
 3SG tomorrow FUT can look.for job DUOC
 ‘From tomorrow he will be able to look for a job.’ [dynamic]

This interpretive restriction sets *được* apart from Present-Day Mandarin cognate *de*, given that the latter expresses both epistemic possibility and ability (Tsai 2001; Wu 2004), see (10). In this respect, *được* however patterns with other Sinitic cognates like Early Mandarin *de* (11a) and Cantonese *dak* (11b), both of which do not yield an epistemic interpretation post-verbally. For ease of exposition, we will use DE to refer to these cognates of *được* when no fine-grained distinction is required.

- (10) *Lisi kan-de-dao zhe-ke shu.* [Mandarin]
 Lisi chop-DE-fall this-CL tree
 ‘Lisi can chop the tree down.’
 (= ‘It is possible for Lisi to chop the tree down.’
 or ‘Lisi is able to chop the tree down.’)

(Wu 2004:272, with minor modifications)

- (11) a. *Yīn yáng shì qì wǔxíng shì zhì yǒu zhè*
 Yin Y ang COP qì five.elements COP substance have this
zhì suǒyǐ zuò dé wùshì chūlái [Early Mandarin]
 substance therefore do DE thing emerge
 ‘Yin and Yang are *qì*, the five elements are substance; because
 they have this substance, they can (= are able to) make things
 emerge.’ (Zhuzhi yulei, 1)
- b. *keoi lo-dak-hei li-seung syu* [Cantonese]
 3SG take-DE-up this-box book
 ‘s/he can [i.e., will manage to] lift this box of books’
 (Cheng & Sybesma 2004:420)

Second, we suggest that *được* needs to appear pre-verbally for a deontic reading of the permissive subtype to emerge, see (12). Permissive modality pertains to permissions given by some social authority. Portner (2009) uses the cover term *priority modals* to refer collectively to deontic, bouletic, and teleological modal expressions. The term ‘priority’ alludes to the speaker’s preference of one possibility over the others (as it is better or having a higher priority) in view of certain circumstances, i.e. rules (deontic), desires (bouletic), or goals (teleological). When it is post-verbal as in (13), modal *được* does not exhibit a permissive reading, although a dynamic reading of the ‘opportunity’ subtype (in the sense of Portner 2009) is possible (alongside an ability reading). To foreshadow, we will argue later that (13) might allow an alternative reading along the lines of ‘That Tí looks for a job is okay’ if *được* is construed as a predicate meaning ‘okay’ or ‘acceptable’; this is still not a permissive reading, however. All in all, we contend that the orderings of *được*-VP and VP-*được* do not freely alternate.

- (12) *Anh ấy được kiếm việc.*
 3SG DUOC look.for job
 ‘He is permitted to look for a job.’ [deontic]

- (13) Anh ấy kiểm việc **được**.
 3SG look.for job DUOC
 ‘(The circumstances are such that) he is able to look for a job.’
 [dynamic]

Adopting Portner’s (2009) terminologies, we view post-verbal *được* in (13) as a circumstantial modal verb. In this capacity, *được* expresses possibilities in view of circumstances concerning the outside world and falls under a non-priority category, given its lack of connection to priority ranking. It is therefore reminiscent of the English *can* as in (14), which Kratzer (1991) describes as a pure circumstantial modal characterized by a circumstantial modal base but an empty ordering source. Accordingly, post-verbal *được* with the opportunity reading is distinct from pre-verbal *được*, a typical priority modal with a deontic ordering source.

- (14) a. *Hydrangeas can grow here.* (Kratzer 1991:646)
 b. *You can see the ocean from here.* (Portner 2009:135)

The previous semantic distinction is confirmed with the syntactic test in (15) (cf. Wu 2004; see also Trinh 2017). Specifically, given that only pre-verbal *được* has a permissive reading, it is the only one embeddable under a permissive predicate like *cho phép* ‘permit’, see (15a). Post-verbal *được* and pre-verbal *có thể* are both disallowed in such an embedding configuration, see (15b,c).

- (15) a. Tèo cho phép Tí **được** kiểm việc.
 Tèo allow Tí DUOC look.for job
 ‘Tèo permits Tí to look for a job.’
 b. *Tèo cho phép Tí kiểm việc **được**.
 Tèo permit Tí look.for job DUOC
 Int: ‘Tèo permits Tí to look for a job.’
 c. *Tèo cho phép Tí **có thể** kiểm việc.
 Tèo permit Tí can look.for job
 Int: ‘Tèo permits Tí to look for a job.’

Similarly, a prohibitive predicate like *cấm* ‘prohibit’ licenses *không được* ‘cannot’, the negated form of *được*, only pre-verbally (16a) but never post-verbally (16b). Such a predicate is also incompatible with *không thể* ‘cannot’, the negated form of *có thể*, see (16c). These tests further substantiate the claim that, in contrast to pre-verbal *được*, post-verbal *được* and pre-verbal *có thể* do not have a deontic reading. Instead, they convey a dynamic reading of opportunity.

- (16) a. *Tèo cấm Tí không được kiểm việc.*
 Tèo prohibit Tí NEG DUOC look.for job
 ‘Tèo prohibits Tí from looking for a job.’
 b. **Tèo cấm Tí kiểm việc không được.*
 Tèo prohibit Tí look.for job NEG DUOC
 Int: ‘Tèo prohibits Tí from looking for a job.’
 c. **Tèo cấm Tí không thể kiểm việc.*
 Tèo prohibit Tí cannot look.for job
 Int: ‘Tèo prohibits Tí from looking for a job.’

Although opportunity *được* and ability *được* are presumed to have the same merge position, they can be distinguished in terms of interpretation. The former focuses on the external situation in which the subject finds himself, while the latter conveys the subject’s intrinsic physical or intellectual capacities. Such capacities are understood as internal circumstances concerning, for example, the strength of the body, character, or intellect (cf. Kratzer 2012). Still, ability reading and opportunity reading are closely related and often grouped under the umbrella term of *dynamic modality* (Palmer 2001; Portner 2009). Rightward modal *được* of any possible reading neatly matches Portner’s (2009) description of *dynamic modal* as a non-priority, non-epistemic element. It can be interpreted neither deontically nor epistemically.

It is important to note that the modal reading of circumstantial possibility is not the only plausible interpretation for post-verbal *được* in (13). More specifically, it can also be read as an independent predicate, conveying a meaning roughly equivalent to ‘okay’ or ‘acceptable’ (cf. Hoàng 2006; Sybesma 2008; Enfield 2003) when the sequence immediately before *được* is construed as forming a constituent. In the

capacity of a predicate, *được* does not express a permissive reading, but simply conveys the speaker's personal evaluation with respect to the proposition represented by the subject. We take predicate *được* to be on a par with adjectival evaluative predicates (in the sense of Lasnik 2005; Stephenson 2007). A permission-like interpretation might still be implied in (13), but this interpretation is necessarily in the form of a pragmatic implicature, not encoded as part of the denotation of *được*.³ In this scenario, the constituent preceding *được* forms a sentential subject of which *được* is predicated. There are at least two syntactic facts supporting this claim. First, the subject-predicate configuration naturally allows for the optional realization of topic marker *thì*, as shown in (17). Second, negative marker *không* 'not' in (18a) does not take scope over *được* (see also Sybesma 2008). To negate *được*, *không* must immediately precede it, see (18b).⁴

- (17) [Subject *Tí kiếm việc*] (*thì*) *được*.
 Tí look.for. job TOP DUOC
 'That Tí looks for a job is okay/acceptable.' [predicative]

- (18) a. [*Tí không kiếm việc*] *được*.
 Tí NEG look.for. job DUOC
 'That Tí does not look for a job is okay/acceptable.' [*được* > NEG]
 NOT: 'Tí cannot look for a job.' [*NEG > *được*]
 b. [*Tí kiếm việc không*] *được*.
 Tí look.for. job NEG DUOC
 'That Tí looks for a job is not okay/acceptable.'

What about Cantonese *dak* as in (19), which evidently displays a deontic (permissive) interpretation post-verbally? Despite its apparent similarity with post-verbal *được* in terms of linear order, Cheng & Sybesma (2004) claim that *dak* ends up linearly succeeding the verb only

³ We thank an anonymous reviewer for urging us to clarify how the predicative meaning of *được* differs from a permissive reading.

⁴ See Duffield (1999, sec. 4) for an early sentential subject analysis of the constituent preceding *được*. Our views differ in that Duffield treats *được* there as an abilitative modal, while for us it is a predicate with no modal reading.

because the verb is raised to attach to its left. This operation is mandatory given that *dak* is considered defective as a bound morpheme, rendering it unable to function as a freestanding modal verb.

- (19) *keoi5 zaa1-dak1 li1-gaa3 ce1.*
 3SG drive-DE this-CL car
 ‘S/he can [i.e., is permitted to] drive this car.
 (Cheng & Sybesma 2004:420)

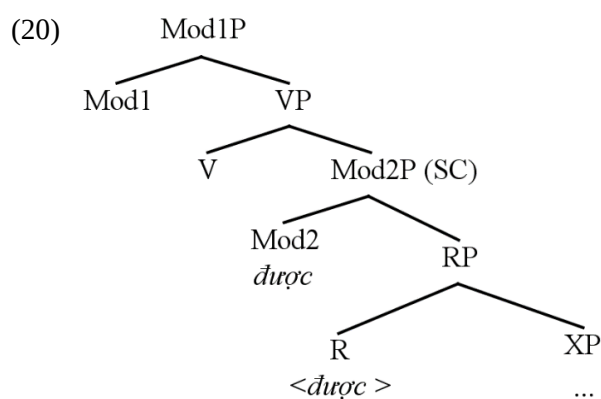
A similar analysis for *duoc* is untenable for several reasons. First, such a verb movement would not derive the right linear order, leaving the surface position of the DP *viéc* ‘job’ in between the main verb and *duoc* in (13) unaccounted for. Second, the sequence preceding *duoc* would not form a constituent, so the topicalization of this sequence should be ruled out, contrary to what is observed in (17). Third, that negation does not scope over *duoc* in (18a) would be puzzling. Finally, such a raising would be optional (cf. permissive *duoc* in pre-verbal position in (12)), which is conceptually undesirable given that syntactic operations should be motivated to achieve an optimal solution in the Minimalist Program. For Cantonese, the movement of the verb is mandatory and well-motivated.

All in all, we maintain that post-verbal *duoc* in the capacity of a modal verb has neither an epistemic nor a deontic interpretation but must be construed dynamically. When rightward *duoc* does not express a modal reading, it is either a resultative marker or an evaluative predicate (or a pragmatic marker, see Section 4). The next section discusses at length Phan’s (2023, 2024a) syntactic analysis of rightward *duoc* to see how it fares with new data featuring a secondary predicate.

3. POST-VERBAL *DUOC*: BETWEEN ASPECTUAL, MODAL, AND PREDICATIVE INTERPRETATIONS

Phan (2024a) suggests that post-verbal modal *duoc* is diachronically derived from resultative marker *duoc* (one of the post-verbal result-denoting particles in Phan 2013), which itself evolves from a second

transitive verb in a V-V construction, presumably via an intermediate stage as an intransitive verb.⁵ We illustrate the diachronic derivation of modal *được* from resultative *được* in (20).



(adapted from Phan 2024a:178)

Specifically, after the fully verbal *được* had been reanalyzed as a resultative marker heading RP, *được* was at first raised to Mod2P to check modal features. A subsequent reanalysis then allows the previously moved *được* to be construed as base-generated in Mod2P. The proposed path of development fits the description of a standard ‘upwards’ reanalysis along the functional structure in the sense of Roberts & Roussou (2003), given that RP with inner aspect features is assumed to be structurally lower than Mod2P. This hierarchy is consistent with how the clausal functional spine is standardly assumed: dynamic modality as part of the TP zone always scopes over and is structurally higher than VP-internal inner aspect (cf. Cinque 1999; see also Phan 2013; Ramchand & Svenonius 2014, a.o.).⁶

⁵ This proposed intransitivization is attributable to a loss of argument structure typical of a grammaticalization process (see Roberts & Roussou 2003).

⁶ The postulation of RP is inspired by Ramchand’s (2008) *resP* (result projection), one of the three components making up the traditional V, within the framework of first phase syntax. Incidentally, Tsai (to appear) advocates for a “second phase syntax” to account for the fact that result projection is structurally distinct from V in Chinese, reflecting

Before continuing with the analysis of modal *được*, let us make a detour and examine in more details the so-called resultative *được* and its aspectual nature. *Được* as a resultative marker has previously been treated as a past tense achievement marker (Duffield 1999), an aspectual element indicating that “the action denoted by the verb has been brought to a successful conclusion” (Sybesma 2008:240), and an aspectual achievement marker assuring the completion of the depicted situation (Phan 2013). In other words, a factual realization of the resultant state of V is often ascribed to resultative *được*, and in its presence, the event is viewed as completed. Empirical data however appears to cast doubt on this characterization: resultative *được* is, in fact, perfectly acceptable in future and irrealis contexts, see (21a) and (21b) respectively, where the actual realization of the event is unconfirmed (see also Section 5).⁷ Note that *được* is infelicitous with a modal reading in these instances.

- (21) a. *Nhất định em sẽ tìm được anh.*⁸
 definitely 1SG FUT look.for DUOC 2SG

the robust analyticity of the language (see also Tsai 2015b). We find it uncontroversial to assume that Vietnamese, another radical analytic language, also naturally permits a result(ative) projection that is distinct from and c-commanded by V.

⁷ We find a similar pattern to post-verbal *được* in the uses of Dongying Mandarin *liu* (a cognate of Standard Mandarin *liao/le*, lit. ‘finish’). Ke (1995) and Song (2016) claim that Dongying Mandarin has two *liu*’s, one telic marker and one modal element denoting the ability to realize the event in V. In (i) the first *liu* marks the depicted event as telic, while the second *liu* as a modal conveys the subject’s ability to realize the event. Modal *liu* is taken to be derived diachronically from *liu* as an Aktionsart marker, repeating the path of grammaticalization from Aktionsart reading to dynamic modal reading proposed for *được* (and its cognates across (South)east Asia). More interestingly, aspectual *liu* is also reported to occur in future and irrealis contexts (Song 2018), highlighting its non-realized nature. Aspectual *liu* heads a VP-internal projection encoding telicity (Song 2018), similar to RP in the case of *được*.

(i) *Te qu liu liu a.*
 he go LIU LIU SFP

‘He is able to get there.’ (Song 2018:286)

⁸ <https://vnexpress.net/nhat-dinh-em-se-tim-duoc-anh-4333355.html>

‘I definitely will find you.’ [resultative]

NOT: ‘I definitely will be able to look for you.’ [*dynamic]

- b. Chúng ta đều muốn tìm được một đại lý
we all want look.for DUOC a agency
đáng tin cậy.⁹
worth trust

‘We all want to find a trustworthy agency.’ [resultative]

NOT: ‘We all want to be able to look for a trustworthy agency.’
[*dynamic]

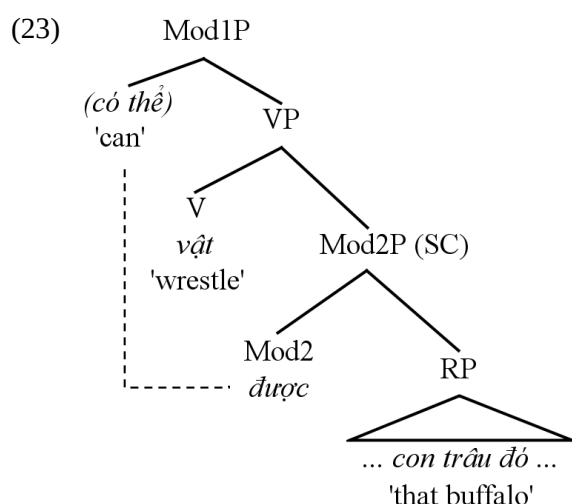
We concur with Duffield (1999) and Phan (2013) that resultative marker *được* is aspectual and heads a VP-internal aspectual projection akin to Travis’s (2010) Inner Aspect Phrase. We however want to emphasize that the contribution of *được* is confined to the realm of telicity-marking only; that is, it defines the terminal point of the event in V without denoting its actual realization. The completion reading often associated with resultative *được* is either encouraged by other tense/aspect markers or simply implied by context.

Now returning to modal *được*, Phan (2023, 2024a) treats rightward *được* with abilitative reading as a defective modal verb heading a functional projection below VP. This projection is licensed by a higher dynamic modal phrase optionally realized with *có thể* in the canonical functional position via *Agree*. The postulation of this higher licensing position aligns with Duffield’s (1999) insight that *có thể* is in the canonical modal position and rightward *được* is “parasitic” on the presence of this projection.¹⁰ We take opportunity *được* as discussed in Section 2, another instance of dynamic modality, to behave in a similar fashion syntactically. The dependency between *có thể* and *được* in a sentence like (3), repeated here as (22), is roughly illustrated in (23).

⁹ <https://www.msig.com.vn/vi/cuoc-song/5-meo-giup-ban-tim-duoc-dai-ly-du-lich-dang-tin-cay>

¹⁰ Duffield’s (1999) analysis however does not explicitly address the merge position of *được* and the syntactic mechanism(s) through which *được* is licensed. It also treats *được* as an adverbial. Given its diachronic development, we prefer to view *được* as a modal verb.

- (22) *Tí có thể vật được con trâu đó.* (= (3))
 Tí can wrestle DUOC CL buffalo that
 ‘Tí can wrestle that buffalo.’



This analysis largely follows Cheng & Sybesma (2003, 2004): the constituent that V selects is viewed as a small clause (SC), and post-verbal *được* heading a Mod2P enters into an *Agree* relation with the higher dynamic projection Mod1P.¹¹

Alternatively, such a dependency can be achieved by assuming an LF movement of *được* to the higher projection for feature-checking purposes (see Wu 2004 for Mandarin). The intuition that there is a tight-knit relationship between *được* and the licensing modal projection is

¹¹ An anonymous reviewer questions how a sentence like (9) can be derived, considering that *được* appears linearly after the object. It is possible that we are dealing with a different configuration here: the object in this case might well be base-generated in spec,VP, acting as the antecedent controlling a PRO within the small clause (cf. Huang 1992; Zhang 2001, i.a.); the linear placement of V with respect to the object is subsequently derived through a V-to-v movement across this noun phrase. It is constructive to note that the object here is not (fully) referential, and the expression *kiếm việc* (lit. ‘seek job’) simply denotes a job-seeking activity (cf. Huang 2006). A definitive answer to this question, however, must await additional research.

captured with either of the operations, as long as locality is obeyed. That is, regardless of whether it is *Agree* or LF movement, an intervener should be prohibited between the two modal projections. Phan (2023) shows that intervention effects occur in the presence of the manner/method *wh*-adverbial *(làm) sao* ‘how’. (24a) demonstrates that the same applies to the alternative form *thế nào* ‘how’. As VP-adjuncts, *(làm) sao* and *thế nào* are potential interveners between VP-external Mod1P and VP-internal Mod2P. When *được* is absent, we assume no such dependency is established, thus the grammaticality of (24b) is straightforward. The same effect is confirmed with manner adverbs like *một cách triệt để* ‘thoroughly’ or *một cách nhanh chóng* ‘quickly’, see (25).

(24) a. **Tí (có thể) giải quyết chuyện này được (làm) sao/ thế nào?*
 Tí can handle matter this can how
 Intended: ‘In which manner can Tí handle this matter?’
 (adapted from Phan 2023:159)

b. *Tí có thể giải quyết chuyện này (làm) sao/ thế nào?*
 Tí can handle matter this how how
 ‘In which manner can Tí handle this matter?’

(25) a. **Tí (có thể) giải quyết chuyện này được một cách triệt để/ nhanh chóng.*
 Tí can handle matter this can thoroughly
quickly

Intended: ‘Tí can handle this matter thoroughly/quickly.’

b. *Tí có thể giải quyết chuyện này một cách triệt để/ nhanh chóng.*
 Tí can handle matter this thoroughly
quickly
 ‘Tí can handle this matter thoroughly/quickly.’

We follow Wu 2004 (inspired by Ernst 1995 and Cinque 1999) in treating manner adverb(ial)s as *head adjuncts*. These adverb(ial)s are intrinsically quantificational and can, therefore, affect other quantificational operations, in contrast with non-quantificational

argument-like adjuncts. Head adjuncts behave like quantifiers and can disrupt the dependency between the two modal projections in (24a) and (25a). See Cheng & Sybesma 2003 and Wu 2004 for similar tests targeting the licensing of Cantonese *dak* and Mandarin *de* respectively.

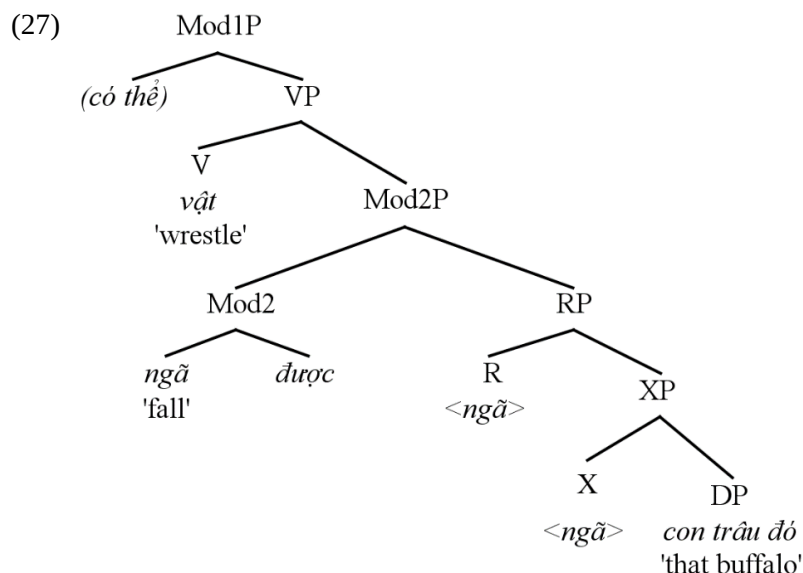
Now that the syntactic analysis for post-verbal *được* is laid out, let us explore how it can be extended to account for cases where a resultative component X, like *ngã* ‘fall (down)’ in (26), is overtly realized. When a predicate X is present, as in (26a), *được* communicates dynamic potentiality: here it is X and the potential of reaching the denoted result/goal that are highlighted (cf. Sybesma 2008). Note that *được* must remain to the right of the V-X sequence. The alternative ordering with *được* sandwiched between V and X is ill-formed in (26b) with the intended reading (but see Section 5).

- (26) a. *Tí vật ngã được con trâu đó.*
 Tí wrestle fall DUOC CL buffalo that
 ‘Tí can wrestle down that buffalo.’
 b. **Tí vật được ngã con trâu đó.*
 Tí wrestle DUOC fall CL buffalo that
 Int: ‘Tí can wrestle down that buffalo.’

Building on the assumption that V selects for modal *được*, which, in turn, selects for an RP denoting telicity, we position X immediately below RP.¹² As the derivation goes, X raises to attach to *được* via R to check Aktionsart features, deriving the right order. See (27) for an illustration.¹³ Raising of X is necessary as *được* is inherently defective: it is unable to independently act as probe for a probe-goal agreement with X. Recall that *được* syntactically depends on a higher modal projection for its dynamic interpretation. After the raising of X, the sequence X-*được* is successfully licensed by Mod1P.

¹² An RP inside SC is assumed even when no overt marker is present (cf. Cheng & Sybesma 2004).

¹³ This movement is reminiscent of the raising of resultative *được* to Mod2P to check modal feature before it was reanalyzed as base-generated in this designated secondary ModP (Phan 2024; see also Meisterernst 2022).



Note that in terms of relative ordering of X and *được*/DE, Vietnamese differs from Chinese varieties like Mandarin and Cantonese as the latter always have X following DE, see (28). Cheng & Sybesma (2004) claim that Cantonese *dak* (as well as the Hakka cognate *tet*) is partially defective, meaning that X only checks features with DE through adjacency. In other words, feature checking occurs only when the two heads are adjacent, close enough for the checking process to take place. It appears that *Agree* through adjacency is not an option for *được*: the only way X can check its modal feature is by incorporating itself to *được*, as *được* is defective and cannot function as a probe.

- (28) a. *Lisi kan-de-dao zhe-ke shu.* [Mandarin] (= (10))
 Lisi chop-DE-fall this-CL tree
 ‘Lisi can chop the tree down.’
 b. *keoi5 lo2-dak1-hei2 li1-seung1 syu1.* [Cantonese] (= (11b))
 3SG take-DE-up this-box book
 ‘S/he can [i.e., will manage to] lift this box of books.’

In brief, we have shown that by maintaining a small clause analysis where *được* merges VP-internally as the head of either an (inner) aspectual phrase or a modal phrase (with the latter merging above the former), we can straightforwardly account for the curious post-verbal position of *được*. The analysis is also capable of dealing with cases where a result component is overtly realized. Given that Vietnamese is a radical head-initial language, for post-verbal *được* to syntactically merge above VP (see, for example, Duffield 1998; Simpson 2001), we will have to assume a raising of VP as the complement of *được* across it to derive the right order. Arguments about empirical difficulties facing this predicate-raising analysis can be found in Duffield 1999. We add that such an analysis also needs to account for the structural position of *có thể* when both *có thể* and *được* co-occur and jointly express a single dynamic construal. Namely, assuming that *có thể* occupies Spec,ModP, there is no longer an available landing site for VP if this is where it is moved to. If VP is raised to the specifier of a higher functional projection, it should precede *có thể*, deriving the wrong linear order.

The next section investigates a special case of *được* in a sentence-final position in a particular type of non-canonical interrogatives. We will show that this instantiation of *được* exhibits none of the above-mentioned readings, but is best characterized as a pragmatic element reflecting speaker's public commitment.

4. TYING UP A LOOSE END: SENTENCE-FINAL *ĐƯỢC* AS A MARKER OF COMMITMENT

We proposed previously that the rightward modal *được* is not derived by movement of its complement, but simply reflects its base position in a VP-internal projection. It is however untrue to assume a low merge position for every occurrence of post-verbal *được*. Sentence-final *được* in (29) is a case in point. To foreshadow, it will be treated as a pragmatic sentence-final particle (SFP) base-generated above the traditional CP. We will show that this SFP does not convey any of the readings previously ascribed to post-verbal *được*, but instead publicly expresses the speaker's commitment to denying a previous utterance deemed

untrue or incredible. To the best of our knowledge, this particular use of *được* has not been addressed in the existing literature.

- (29) *Sao/ gì/ đâu mà Tí có tiền được?!*
 what what where MP Tí have money DUOC
 ‘It’s not the case Tí has money! (*I don’t believe he does.*)’

With this pragmatic import, *được* is typically found in non-canonical interrogatives marked with sentence-initial adverbs (with *wh*-word origin) like *sao/gì* ‘what’ and *đâu* ‘where’, which Phan & Tsai (2022) refer to as a type of Surprise-Denial Questions (SDQs). These interrogatives signal the speaker’s dismissal of an utterance as untrue or incredible (typically accompanied by a confrontational tone), given an incompatibility between the proposition expressed by the utterance and the information state of the speaker.¹⁴ SDQs thus differ from standard information-seeking questions where the featured *wh*-words simply represent the inquired information. The exclusive presence of SFP *được* in these SDQs is suggestive of its sensitivity towards the content of its prejacent: *được* appears to be compatible only with statements in the form of a denial. Phan & Tsai (2024) discuss several phenomena of a similar nature. For instance, SFPs *đâu* and *cơ* as commitment markers are exclusively compatible with statements that are, respectively, a contradiction and a correction (in the sense of Asher & Gillies 2003).¹⁵ The compatibility of different types of statements with distinct commitment particles is illustrated with (30-31).

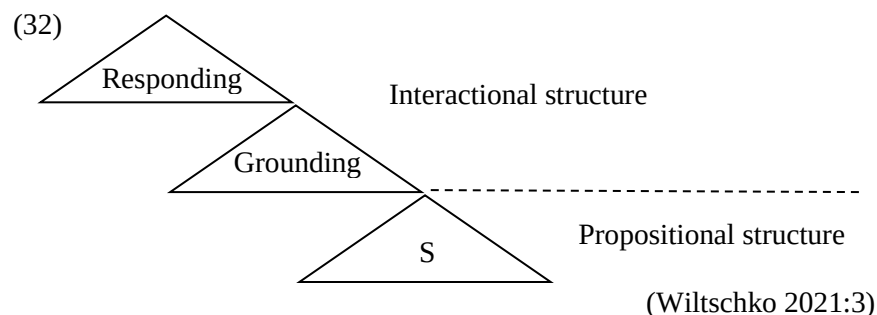
- (30) a. *Tí đâu có tiền đâu/*cơ/*được!* [contradiction]
 Tí NEG have money SFP SFP DUOC
 ‘It is untrue that Tí has money! (*I am telling you he does not!*)’

¹⁴ Phan & Tsai (2024) assume that these CP-level adverbs in SDQs are associated with an illocutionary operator of denial, effectively turning the host sentence into an objection to a previous utterance.

¹⁵ A correction is understood as a verbal disagreement with affirmative polarity, while a contradiction is a disagreement with wide-scope negation (Phan & Tsai 2024).

- b. *Tí có tiền *đâu/ cơ/ *được!* [correction]
 Tí have money SFP SFP DUOC
 ‘What is true is that Tí has money! (*I am telling you he does!*)’
- (31) *Sao/ gì/ đâu mà Tí có tiền *đâu/*cơ/ được?!* [denial]
 what what where MP Tí have money SFP SFP DUOC
 ‘I deny it that Tí has money! (*I do not believe he does.*)’

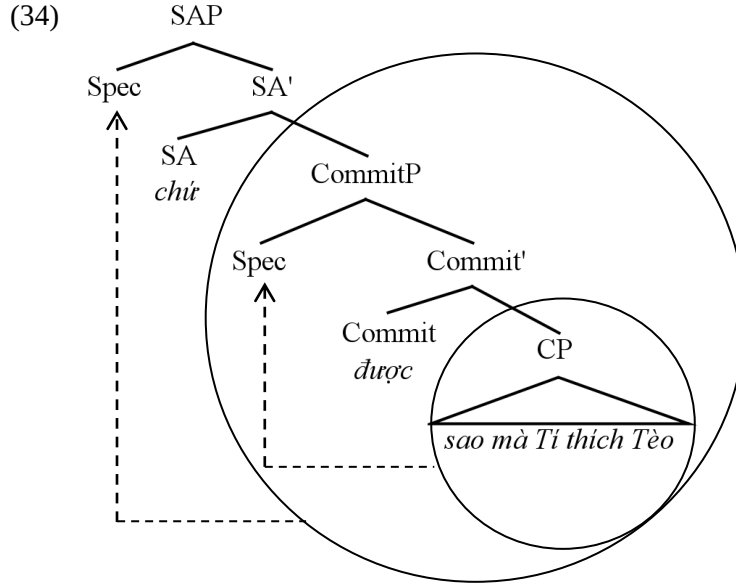
Phan 2024b suggests that Vietnamese SFPs with a pragmatic import (i.e. those anchored to the speech participants) are merged in what Wiltschko & Heim 2016 (et seq.) dub the *interactional domain*, see (32) for illustration. This separate domain materializes the highest structural layers of the functional spine of an utterance and is concerned with how a propositional content is publicly negotiated between the speech participants before it enters their shared common ground (see Stalnaker 1978; Farkas & Bruce 2010). The Responding layer (roughly corresponding to Speech Act Phrase in Phan 2024b) hosts elements marking the interaction between the speech participants. The Grounding layer either encodes or modifies the speaker’s public commitment towards a proposition, which generally overlaps with Krifka’s (2015, 2023) Commitment Phrase. We adopt Krifka’s label, suggesting that SFP *được* heads a Commitment Phrase highlighting the speaker’s own commitment to a denial to a previous utterance, given the conflict between the proposition expressed and the speaker’s doxastic state. The utterance hosting SFP *được* therefore effectively forms an objection to the addressee’s proposal to integrate a proposition into the shared common ground.



But could we just take *được* in (29) to be an epistemic modal verb that simply scopes under sentential negation to derive something like “It cannot be the case that...”? We reject this possibility based on three arguments. First, Section 2 already shows that post-verbal *được* does not have an epistemic reading. Second, sentence-final *được* has a *use-conditional* meaning (following Recanati 2004; see also Gutzman 2015) and is omissible without affecting the truth-conditions of the host sentence. *Được* as an SFP is in apparent contrast with modal *được*, which is required to guarantee the modal reading in the absence of the higher *có thể*. Third, if SFP *được* was an epistemic here, it had to merge at the lower end of CP and was scoped over by sentential negation at the upper end of CP. This low position should have no impact on how CP interacts with higher pragmatic layers. This is however not the case: SFP *chứ*, for example, is unable to occur in the SDQ in a sentence like (33a) unless *được* precedes it, see (33b). In syntactic terms, we postulate that *chứ* can only select for a phrase headed by *được* in this denial context, assuming that a rightward SFP scopes over a leftward SFP and linear order is derived through a Kaynian “roll-up” movement.¹⁶ See (34) for the derivation of (33b).

- (33) a. *Sao/ gì/ đâu mà Tí thích Tèo **chứ**?!
 what what where MP Tí like Tèo SFP
 Int: ‘It is not the case Tí likes Tèo! (*I do not believe it. Please respond.*)’
 b. Sao/ gì/ đâu mà Tí thích Tèo **được chứ**?!
 what what where MP Tí like Tèo DUOC SFP
 ‘It is not the case Tí likes Tèo! (*I do not believe it. Please respond.*)’

¹⁶ But see Phan 2024b for an overview of a competing analysis where no movement is assumed.



We assume, following Phan (2024), that *chứ* in (33) realizes a Speech Act Phrase (the higher part of the interactional domain). Its pragmatic import is a *call on address* (à la Beyssade & Marandin 2006) to take up the speaker’s utterance and respond to it. In this capacity, *chứ* is unable to directly select for a denial, which does not typically ask for the addressee’s response. The inclusion of *được* turns a bare denial into a speaker’s commitment; this allows *chứ* to engage the addressee, urging him to take up the speaker’s stance and agree with it.

Cross-linguistically, the affinity between SFP *được* and SDQ contexts appears to have quite a mirror image in Cantonese, see (35). Note that sentence-initial *mat1* ‘what’ here should impose an emphatic, maximal wide-scope negation reading along the lines of ‘it’s not the case that...’ (comparable to Vietnamese *gì/sao* and Mandarin *shenme* ‘what’), and should not be taken simply as an injection expressing surprise or disbelief as shown in the translation. The use of *me1* here “explicitly commits S[peaker] to believing not *p*” (Heim et al. 2016:121), *p* being the discourse-prominent proposition. In other words, *me1* induces a

paraphrased reading of ‘I do not believe it’ as a marker of public commitment to a disagreement, just like in the case of SFP *được*.

- (35) a. *mat1 ngo5 san1 joeng5 zo2 zek3 gau2 me1?*
 what 1SG new keep ASP CL dog PRT
 ‘What, I have a new dog?! (*But I don’t!*)’ (Heim et al. 2016:121)
- b. *mat1 lei5 m4-zi1 ge3 me1?*
 what 2SG NEG-know PRT PRT
 ‘What, you don’t know?!’ (Matthews & Yip 1994:311)

5. CONCLUDING REMARKS

This paper focuses on instances of *được* which appear to the right of a main verb, showing that *được* in this linear position does not always correspond to a modal auxiliary, but can also serve as an aspectual marker, an evaluative predicate, or a pragmatic particle. We argue that post-verbal *được* as a modal element does not exhibit deontic or epistemic readings. In the capacity of a modal auxiliary, it primarily communicates the subject’s intrinsic ability; nevertheless, it can also denote (external) circumstantial factors enabling the subject’s action, or solely focus on a result component X and the potential of it being realized. If a sentence-final *được* is not interpreted dynamically, it can serve as either a main predicate meaning roughly ‘okay’ or ‘acceptable’, an aspect marker marking telicity, or a commitment-marking device publicly committing the speaker to a denial. By maintaining that *được* can head a secondary modal projection (as well as an inner aspectual projection) below VP, we offer a coherent account for the otherwise perplexing linear placement in which *được* must always follow the main verb.

Regarding word orders involving a result component X, a remark is necessary here. We have learned previously that X raises to attach to *được* for feature-checking purposes. If no raising happens, ill-formedness ensues, see (26b), repeated here as (36).

- (36) **Tí vật được ngã con trâu đó.* (= (24b))
 Tí wrestle DUOC fall CL buffalo that
 Int: ‘Tí can wrestle down that buffalo.’

A somewhat similar observation is made by Phan (2013): specifically, resultative *được* always follows completive particles like *ra* ‘out’, rendering the reverse order ungrammatical, as seen in (37). Our approaches nevertheless differ in how the VP-internal hierarchy of telic-related elements is presented. Phan (2013) assumes an extended Inner Aspect domain where a Completive projection (headed by completive particles like *hết* ‘end’ or *xong* ‘finish’) merges above a Resultative projection (headed by resultative particles like *được*). That is, their linear order is claimed to reflect their structural hierarchy.

- (37) **Họ đã tìm được ra cách chữa bệnh AIDS*
 3PL ANT find DUOC out way treat disease AIDS
 Int: ‘They have found the cure for AIDS.’ (Phan 2013:112)

Interestingly, we observe that a V-*được*-X ordering is deemed acceptable, but only within a hypothetical context. In this scenario, X is interpreted as a mere projected endpoint or result state of V, and the non-realization of the event(uality) X denotes is highlighted. In (38a), the prospect of the ‘falling’ event being realized is treated as highly unlikely. In (38b), the event is viewed as untrue or incredible. In (38c), the event is a goal to be achieved. Similarly, *được* can in fact legitimately precede completive particles in irrealis contexts like (39).

- (38) a. *Nếu [Tí vật được ngã con trâu đó], tao cho*
 if Tí wrestle DUOC fall CL buffalo that 1SG give
nó một triệu đô.
 3SG one million dollar
 ‘I’ll give him a million dollars if he could wrestle down that buffalo.’
 b. *Gì mà [Tí vật được ngã con trâu đó]!*
 what PART Tí wrestle DUOC fall CL buffalo that
 ‘It is not the case Tí could wrestle down that buffalo!’

c. Để [Tí vật được ngã con trâu đó] thì nó
 for Tí wrestle DUOC fall CL buffalo that CONJ 3SG
 phải khỏe bằng ba người thường.
 must strong equal three person regular
 ‘For Tí to wrestle down that buffalo, he must grow as strong as
 three regular men.’

(39) Nếu tìm được ra lời giải cho câu hỏi hóc búa này [...] ¹⁷
 if look.for DUOC out solution for question tough this
 ‘If you can find the solution for this tough (math) problem [...]’

For reasons of space, a thorough discussion of this reverse ordering must await future research. For now, we simply suggest a connection between the post-được position of telic elements with their strict non-realization. One possible extension to our current analysis is to hypothesize that được in (38-39) materializes some kind of mood/aspect marker endowed with, say, [+unrealized] feature. Telic elements then agree with được through adjacency, eliminating the need for raising. It remains to be seen how Phan’s (2013) postulation of the fixed hierarchy of telic particles reconciles with these apparent counterexamples.

Two final notes are in order. First, this use of được is distinguished from its Aktionsart use: the latter syntactically marks the telicity of the V-event but says nothing about whether an endpoint has been reached, while the former explicitly highlights the resultant state as non-realized/hypothetical. Second, this “non-realized” interpretation of được is in fact not so extraordinary given that the V-X-được and the V-được-X ordering both communicate some sort of irreality. Their distinction is quite reminiscent of von Prince et al.’s (2022) split of the *irrealis domain* into the potential and the counterfactual: we have the potential interpretation when X precedes được and the counterfactual interpretation when X follows được. We hope to return to this issue in a future project.

¹⁷ <https://cafebiz.vn/giai-duoc-5-bai-toan-hoc-bua-nay-chuyen-ban-tro-thanh-ti-phu-do-la-chi-con-la-thoi-gian-20161-219-10313748.chn>

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Trần Phan
Graduate Institute of Linguistics
National Tsing Hua University
101, Sec. 2, Guangfu Rd., East Dist., Hsinchu, Taiwan
tranphan@gapp.nthu.edu.tw

Barbara Meisterernst
Institute of Linguistics
University of Stuttgart
Keplerstr. 17, 70174 Stuttgart, Germany
barbara.meisterernst@ling.uni-stuttgart.de

越南語動詞後的「được」：
表達體貌、情態、謂詞及說話者承諾的用法

潘玉陳¹、梅思德²

¹國立清華大學

²司徒加特大學

首先，本文主張越南語中的「được」（字面意義為「獲得、取得、得到」）只有在作為動詞後情態助動詞時能表達能願模態意。動後「được」若沒有此解讀，則不是情態助動詞，而是作為終點性（telicity）的體貌標記、評價性謂詞（evaluative predicate）或語用標記。接著，我們探討了動後「được」的句法和解釋特性，且採納「được」在表達動相（Aktionsart）或能願模態意時是動詞組內部（VP-internal）功能投射的看法。在具有否決念力（denial force）的句子中，句末的「được」被分析為一種承諾（commitment）標記（Krifka 2015, 2023；Wiltschko & Heim 2016），用來表達說話者對先前話語的否決。

關鍵字：動後「được」、體貌性、情態性、謂語性、說話者承諾、句法-語用介面